Afghanistan's largest copper mining site in Hajigak in 2011 (though little movement occurred on the project). It was a spectacular show of support that had created a buzz in Afghan circles about India's growing developmental footprint in the country.[21]

Inspired from India's successful community engagement experiences in Sri Lanka and Nepal, hundreds of SDPs were launched in Afghanistan in conjunction with providing food assistance for primary schools, supplying 250,000 tonnes of wheat, and offering training to about 1,000 Afghan army officers every year.[22] Most of these goods reached Afghanistan via Iran. To make such linkages viable, a tripartite preferential trade agreement was signed with both Afghanistan and Iran in 2003. Fearing Indian economic domination in the region, Pakistan refused to ship Indian wheat (and other products) to Afghanistan via its territory on spurious grounds that the wheat was infested and carried diseases.[23] In response, India converted the wheat into high-protein biscuits that would not become spoiled in the four to six weeks that it took Indian goods to reach Afghanistan via Iran's Bandar Abbas port and the through the Islam Qala border in Herat.[24] The Zaranj-Delaram highway was India's strategic response to further bridge this geographical gap with Afghanistan (exaggerated by hostilities with Pakistan). Though being actively used by the Taliban and generally unsafe for travel, the highway is meant to help reduce Kabul's dependence on the Karachi port for its sea links and allow India to ship goods and material to Afghanistan at lower costs. The Indian Development Cooperation Research (IDCR) mapped India's total development cooperation with Afghanistan between 2002 and 2013 as such.

As per Graph 1, India's total aid commitment and expenditure, despite a slight slump between 2009 and 2011, grew in 2013–14. Graph 2 further highlights that 42 per cent of India's total aid to Afghanistan went into infrastructural development, 25 per cent in government administration, 24 per cent in provision of food, 3 per cent each in multi-sector engagement and health, 2 per cent in education, and 1 per cent in training and capacity building. In addition to these projects, the number of Indian citizens in Afghanistan was estimated at 3,000 in 2011.[25]